

University of North Texas at Dallas
Fall 2025
SYLLABUS

ENGL 3347-0081 Hip Hop Rhetoric (3 hrs)	
Department of Languages, Linguistics, and Rhetoric	School of Liberal Arts and Sciences
Instructor Name:	Dr. Robert Tinajero
Office Location:	Founders Hall 258
Email Address:	robert.tinajero@untDallas.edu (or Canvas messaging)
Office Phone	972-338-1537 (emailing or Canvas messaging is best)
Office Hours:	Monday: 9:00-1:00 and Wednesday 11:30-1:30
Classroom:	Founders Hall (Dal2) Room 213
Class Dates:	Mondays 11:30-12:50 (hybrid course)
Course Catalog Description:	An analysis of the rhetorical output of Hip Hop music and culture with a focus on various social topics including, but not limited to, race, gender, sexuality, the criminal justice system, literary devices, and identity. Prerequisite: ENG 1313
Required Texts and Software:	No textbook is required. All material will be posted in Canvas.
Useful Resources:	Grammar Help: Grammarly.com 24-Hour Writing Tutoring: BrainFuse (see info. in Canvas) Academic Writing Resources: https://www.blueletters.com/writing-resources

Access to Learning Resources:	UNT Dallas Library: phone: (972) 780-1616 web: http://www.untDallas.edu/library email: library@untDallas.edu UNT Dallas Bookstore: phone: (972) 780-3652 web: http://www.untDallas.edu/bookstore e-mail: untDallas@bkstr.com
Supported Browsers Chrome Firefox Flash 28, 29 (for audio/video) Internet Explorer 11 Safari 10, 11 Supported Devices: iPhone Android Chromebook	Getting Help with Canvas: Canvas 24 /7 Phone Support for Students: 1-833-668-8634 Canvas Help Resources: web: https://community.canvaslms.com/docs/DOC-10701 For additional assistance, contact Student Assistance (Distance Learning): Founders Hall, Rm 124 phone: (972) 338-5580

Tablet users can use the Canvas app	email: distancelearning@untdallas.edu If you are working with Canvas 24/7 Support to resolve a technical issue, make sure to keep me updated on the troubleshooting progress. If you have a course-related issue (course content, assignment troubles, quiz difficulties) please contact me during office hours or by email.
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Course Overview:

An analysis of the rhetorical output of Hip Hop music and culture with a focus on various social topics including, but not limited to, race, gender, sexuality, the criminal justice system, literary devices, and identity. Various readings and media will be provided for analysis and discussion.

Learning Objectives/Outcomes:

At the end of this course, students should expect to gain significant experience in the following areas:

Learning Outcome 1: Develop habits of critical analysis of, and aesthetic appreciation for, Hip Hop's artistic and rhetorical productions.

Learning Outcome 2: Establish relevant context to relate the historical development of Hip Hop to modern society.

Learning Outcome 3: Analyze various social issues through the lens of Hip Hop culture and music.

Learning Outcome 5: Write and communicate in various modes, media, and/or rhetorical contexts.

Course Schedule

- Schedule is subject to change by the instructor; any changes to this schedule will be communicated on the Announcements page of the class Canvas site.

Date	Weekly Topics and Readings	Assignments Due
Week 1	- Class Welcome and Introductions - Discussion about the terms "Hip Hop" and "rap" - Discussion about students' connections to Hip Hop and the relevancy of studying Hip Hop in an academic setting	- HW: Turn in Blog Link - HW: Read/watch the course material
	- Syllabus Review - Setting up the blog - How to write and post blog essays - Skim through sample student blog essays	
Week 2	General Understanding of Hip Hop Culture and Rapping - The Six Elements of Hip Hop - Videos: DJing, MCing, Beatboxing, Breakdancing, Graffiti, and Knowledge - Encyclopedia Excerpts: "Hip Hop", "Griot" and "Rapping" - Optional Reading: "The Complete History of Hip Hop" by Hayley Milliman	Blog Essay 1 Due (on blogging site)

Week 3	• Why Study Hip Hop and Rap? • Lecture and Discussion: Why study Hip Hop culture and rap music? • Academic Article: “Hip Hop Rhetoric: Relandscaping the Rhetorical Tradition”	• Blog Essay 2 Due
	• Optional Reading: “Hip-hop, identity, and conflict: Practices and transformations of a metropolitan culture” by Luca Benvenga	
Week 4	• Do rappers have a social responsibility regarding drugs, violence, language, social issues, etc.? • Various videos and songs featuring Camron, Eminem, Notorious B.I.G., T.I., YG, Comethazine, Nas, Michael Eric Dyson, Bun B, Lil Pump, etc. • “Democratization of Knowledge” Wikipedia	• Blog Essay 3 Due • Setup and post Podcasting link
	• Write the blog essay • Create podcasting account and post link	
Week 5	• Peer Feedback on Blog Essays + Podcasting Introduction • Read, discuss, and provide peer feedback on blog essays • Information on podcasting platform • Practice podcast episode	• Blog Essay 4 Due (about podcast episode)
	• Listen to previous student’s podcast episode • Write a blog essay that reflects on the student’s podcast episode	
Week 6	• Cultural Appropriation? • Music Video: “Fancy” by Iggy Azalea • Article: “Iggy Azalea’s Post-Racial Mess” from Salon • Various Music Videos • The Olympics Controversy: Raygun and Breakdancing • Discussion about cultural appropriation through the lens of hip hop culture and rap music	• Podcast Episode 1 Due
	• Create and post podcast episode	
Week 7	• Female Rappers: Misogyny or Empowerment? • Various Music Videos: “Make it Rain”, “How Many Licks?”, “Twerk”, Sexy Red, Sukihana, etc. • Academic Article: “Misogyny in Rap Music” from SAGE Journal	• Podcast Episode 2 Due
	• Create and post podcast episode	
Week 8	• Guest Speakers • Guest speakers will visit the class	• Podcast Episode 3 Due
	• Create and post podcast episode	
Week 9	• Beef? • PM Dawn vs. KRS One, Tupac vs. Biggie, Kendrick vs. Drake • Various videos, articles, and social media content	• Blog Essay 5 Due

	- Article: “Rap ‘beef’ as public spectacle is a dangerous game that artists rarely win” in The Conversation - Academic Article: “Bullet on the Charts: Beef, the Media Industry and Rap Music in America” by Eli Sweet	
Week 10	Hip Hop and Policing: F the Police? - Article: “Top Ten Hip Hop Songs Against Policing” in HipHopGoldenAge.com - Various Music Videos by N.W.A., Wacka Flocka, Cypress Hill, etc. - Interview Videos: “Ice-T Interview on CenterStage”, “T.I. Interview on The Daily Show with Trevor Noah”, “Killer Mike Interview on VLADTV about Policemen” - Article: “Something is Hurting the Morale in Police Departments Across America” - Video: “University Lecturer-Rapper Discusses Hip Hop’s Influence on Police Brutality” from University of Maryland’s Writer’s Bloc - Music Videos: “Close Your Eyes and Count to F**K” by Run the Jewels, “The Blacker the Berry” by Kendrick Lamar - Article: “How Hip Hop Holds Blacks Back” from CityJournal.org - Article: “Rappers Are Defending Their Right to Anti-Cop Lyrics in the Supreme Court” from Vice News	Podcast Episode 4 Due
Week 11	Picasso with a Pen: Literary Devices and Rap as Artistic Expression - Video: Rapping, deconstructed: The Best Rhymers of All Time” from Vox - Various TikToks from @dissectpodcast - Lecture: Allusion, End Rhyme, Simple Rhyme, and Multisyllabic rhyme. - Various song examples - Lyric writing practice - Optional Reading Suggestion: <i>Book of Rhymes</i> by Adam Bradley	Practice writing lyrics
Week 12	Rap as Artistic Expression (continued) - Lecture: Alliteration and Metaphor - Various song examples - Create and turn in rap lyrics	Rap Lyrics Due
Week 13	Hip Hop and Religion - Academic Article: “Hip Hop and Religion: Gangsta Rap’s Christian Rhetoric” by Robert Tinajero - Class discussion - Create and post podcast episode	Podcast Episode 5 Due
Week 14	Hip Hop and Politics - Academic Article: “Hip Hop’s Message About Presidents Clinton, Bush, Obama, Trump, Biden, etc.” by Robert Tinajero - Various songs, videos, and social media posts - Class discussion	Begin research for final project

	• Write and post the blog essay • Begin researching global Hip Hop • Final project options discussed	
Week 15	• Globalization of Hip Hop • Student research on non-American Hip Hop	
	• Continue researching	
Week 16	• Globalization of Hip Hop Final Projects Due • Discussion on final projects	• Final Project Due

Grade Breakdown

Assignments	Professionalism	20%
	Blog Essays	20%
	Podcast Episodes	20%
	Rap Lyrics Project	20%
	Final Project	20%
Total		100

Course Evaluation Methods

Student performance in this course will be evaluated by the following:

Blog Essays – Students will write several short-answer blog essays connected to course content and class discussions.

Podcast Episodes – Students will create and publish a number of podcast episodes where they discuss and analyze various course topics.

Rap Lyrics Project – Students will learn about common literary devices through the lens of rap lyrics the be asked to produce lyrics that contain those literary elements.

Final Project – Students will be tasked with completing a final project and will be given options to choose from which may include a paper, presentation, or various other media.

Professionalism – Students are expected to conduct themselves as professional students which includes regular attendance, class participation, and general courtesy.

Grade Determination:

A = 90% or greater
B = 80 – 89 %
C = 70 – 79 %
D = 60 – 69 %
F = Less than 60%

General Course Policies and Procedures

Participation/Professionalism Policy

Students must act professionally throughout the course to meet the following expectations:

- Students should treat each other with courtesy and professionalism in any interaction throughout the course. Please also see the Openness/Constructive Criticism and Diversity/Tolerance policies below.
- Student communication should always strive to meet professional standards of grammar, mechanics, punctuation, spelling, capitalization, etc. All communication should be treated as if your job (or grade) depended on it.
- Students need to complete their work for me and for each other in a timely manner, and students should be responsive to requests from their peers or myself.

Attendance

A significant part of professionalism is showing up prepared, so attendance is mandatory and will follow these rules:

- In each 15-week semester, students may have up to two unexcused absences without penalty. These are referred to as “free” absences.
- For each unexcused absence exceeding two, a student’s final Professionalism grade will be reduced by five points.
- Six or more unexcused absences may result in an absence failure and a grade of “F” in the course.
- Any student who is late to class (this means that the student was not in class when the role was taken), or who leaves class before the instructor has dismissed the class, will be charged with being late. Being late affects the Professional grade.
- If the student has a life event that will lead to several absences, the student should schedule a meeting with the instructor to discuss the situation.

Grading and Assignment Policies

Late Assignment Policy

An assignment will be considered “late” if:

- The assignment is submitted after the assignment’s due date/time has passed.
- The wrong assignment or document is submitted.
- The assignment is submitted through the wrong channel (e.g., it is submitted by email when it was due on Canvas).

The grading policy for late assignments is as follows:

- Late papers and projects will have 10 points taken off for every day they are late; for quizzes and exams, 15 points will be taken off for every class period they are taken late; some quizzes and exams (like final exams) will not be allowed to be taken late but that stipulation will be communicated to students if it is the case.

Missed Assignment Policy

Any assignment will receive a grade of zero if it is never turned in or if the late policy penalty has led to the subtraction of so many points that the grade reaches zero.

Instructor Response Times

I will do my utmost to get back to you promptly. In general, you can expect a response to emails or Canvas Inbox messages within 24 hours during the week and 48 hours on the weekends and holidays.

Office phone and voicemail are not the best methods for contacting me; voicemails will generally take much longer to get responded to than emails or Canvas Inbox messages.

Technology Policies

Email

You must check your UNT Dallas email daily, as this will be my primary method of communication with the class and is the default email account for Blackboard; make sure you can log into this email from day one. **You will also need to send emails from your UNT Dallas account;** emails sent from other addresses regularly land in spam, and I am not responsible for delayed or missing replies if this occurs.

Canvas

Course materials will be posted to the course Canvas page. Class announcements will also come through Canvas or email, so **log on at least once a day or set up notifications**. Information will be posted in the Modules section of Canvas. You can turn on notifications in Settings.

Writing Center

The UNT Dallas Writing Center offers free, one-on-one or group tutoring services to help students become better writers. They work with students on any type of project and can help students at any stage of the writing process, from brainstorming and outlining to citing and looking over a final draft.

The Writing Center is located on the 2nd floor of the Student Center building in the Learning Commons area.

To make an appointment, browse the Writing Center's online resources, or see a list of our student FAQ's, please visit www.untDallas.edu/wc. If students cannot come in for a face-to-face appointment, students can take advantage of our free online tutoring service through the UNT Dallas Writing by scheduling an appointment via WOnline. To submit drafts and get more information about this service, visit <https://untDallas.mywconline.com/>.

To make the best use of your time, please bring as much information as possible with you to your appointment (assignment, grading rubric, previous graded papers from the class, etc.). The Writing Center will not proofread papers or talk with you about grades, but they will help you become better writers over time.

BrainFuse and Grammarly

BrainFuse is a free, online tutoring resource for all UNTD students. Students can send drafts of their papers to BrainFuse and receive valuable feedback. This feedback will help you write better papers and content and thus get better grades.

A simple tool to help you find and fix grammar errors is Grammarly. It is a website and integrated tool that you can use when writing anything.

University Policies and Procedures

Students with Disabilities (ADA Compliance)

The University of North Texas at Dallas makes reasonable academic accommodations for students with disabilities. Students seeking accommodation must first register with the Disabilities Services Office (DSO) to verify their eligibility. If a disability is verified, the DSO will provide you with an accommodation letter to be delivered to faculty to begin a private discussion regarding your specific needs in a course. You may request accommodation at any time, however, DSO notices of accommodation should be provided as early as possible in the semester to avoid any delays in implementation. Note that a student must obtain a new letter of accommodation for every semester and must meet/communicate with each faculty member prior to implementation in each class. Students are strongly encouraged to deliver letters of accommodation during faculty office hours or by appointment. Faculty members have the authority to ask students to discuss such letters during their designated office hours to protect the privacy of the student. For additional information see the Disability Services Office website at <http://www.untDallas.edu/disability>. You may also contact them by phone at 972-338-1777; by email at UNTDDisability@untDallas.edu on the first floor of the Student Center.

Canvas Instructure Accessibility Statement:

University of North Texas at Dallas is committed to ensuring that online and hybrid courses are usable by all students and faculty including those with disabilities. If you encounter any difficulties with technologies, please contact our ITSS Department. To better assist them, you would want to have the operating system, web browser and information on any assistive technology being used. The Canvas Instructure Accessibility Statement is provided at <https://www.canvaslms.com/accessibility>.

NOTE: Additional instructional technology tools, such as Turnitin, Respondus, Panopto, and publisher cartridge content (i.e. MyLab, Pearson, etc.) may NOT be fully ADA compliant. Please contact our Disability Office should you require additional assistance utilizing any of these tools.

Academic Integrity

Academic integrity is a hallmark of higher education. You are expected to abide by the University's code of Academic Integrity policy. Any person suspected of academic dishonesty (i.e., cheating or plagiarism) will be handled in accordance with the University's policies and procedures. Refer to the UNT Dallas Academic Integrity Policy in the appropriate Catalog at <http://dallascatalog.unt.edu>.

Academic dishonesty includes, but is not limited to, cheating, plagiarizing, fabrication of information or citations, facilitating acts of dishonesty by others, having unauthorized possession of examinations, submitting work of another person or work previously used without informing the instructor, or tampering with the academic work of other students.

Web-based Plagiarism Detection: Please be aware in some courses, students may be required to submit written assignments to Turnitin, a web-based plagiarism detection service, or another method. If submitting to Turnitin, please remove your title page and other personal information.

Applied English Program's AI Policy

The UNT-Dallas Applied English program acknowledges the evolving capabilities of Artificial Intelligence (AI) technologies and their various effects on student writing and content creation. The program and the Department of Languages, Linguistics, and Rhetoric is focused on implementing AI-Aware strategies and fostering an environment that emphasizes the ethical and strategic use of AI. Instructors are encouraged to provide clear information, strategies, and policies on AI use in each course and assignment, and students are expected to use AI in an ethical manner. The Applied English program will work at creating an environment of instructor-student-technology collaboration as we move forward in a society where students must learn how to critically harness the capabilities of new technologies.

Classroom Etiquette

Students are encouraged to contribute their perspectives and insights to class discussions. However, offensive & inappropriate language (swearing) and remarks offensive to others of nationalities, ethnic groups, sexual preferences, religious groups, genders, or other ascribed statuses will not be tolerated. Disruptions which violate the Code of Student's Rights, Responsibilities, and Conduct will be referred to the Dean of Students as the instructor deems appropriate (UNTD Policy 7.001 found at <https://untsystem.policysystem.com/dotNet/documents/?docid=1278&public=true>).

Classroom Disruption

Students are expected to always engage with the instructor and other students in this class in a respectful and civil manner to promote a classroom environment that is conducive to teaching and learning. Students who engage in disruptive behavior will be directed to leave the classroom. A student who is directed to leave class due to disruptive behavior is not permitted to return to class until the student meets with a representative from the Dean of Students Office. It is the student's responsibility to meet with the Dean of Students before class meets again and to provide the instructor confirmation of the meeting. A student who is directed to leave class will be assigned an unexcused absence for that class period and any other classes the student misses because of not meeting with the Dean of Students. The student is responsible for material missed during all absences, and the instructor is not responsible for providing missed material. In addition, the student will be assigned a failing grade for assignments, quizzes or examinations missed and will not be allowed to make up the work.

The Code of Student's Rights, Responsibilities, and Conduct (**UNTD Policy 7.001** found at <https://untsystem.policytech.com/dotNet/documents/?docid=1278&public=true>) describes disruption as the obstructing or interfering with university functions or activity, including any behavior that interferes with students, faculty, or staff access to an appropriate educational environment. Examples of disruptive behavior that may result in a student being directed to leave the classroom include but are not limited to: failure to comply with reasonable directive of University officials, action or combination of actions that unreasonably interfere with, hinder, obstruct, or prevents the right of others to freely participate, threatening, assaulting, or causing harm to oneself or to another, uttering any words or performing any acts that cause physical injury, or threaten any individual, or interfere with any individual's rightful actions, and harassment. You are encouraged to read the Code of Student's Rights, Responsibilities, and Conduct for more information related to behaviors that could be considered disruptive.

Course Evaluations

Student evaluations of teaching effectiveness are a requirement for all organized classes at UNT Dallas. This short survey will be made available to you at the end of the semester via your campus email, providing you a chance to comment on how this class is taught. I (as the instructor) will not have access to the results of the evaluations until after final grades have been posted. I am very interested in the feedback I get from students, as I work to continually improve my teaching. I consider students' evaluations to be an important part of your participation in this class.

Sexual Harassment, Sexual Misconduct, Intimate Partner Violence and Stalking

UNT Dallas is committed to creating a safe learning environment for all members of our community, free from gender and sex-based discrimination, including sexual harassment, domestic and dating violence, sexual assault, and stalking, in accordance with Title IX, Texas laws and University Policies. Please note that all employees are mandated reporters and must report all instances of sexual misconduct, dating violence, sexual assault, domestic violence and stalking to the Title IX Coordinator. If you or someone you know has experienced any form of sex or gender-based discrimination or violence and wish to speak to the Title IX Coordinator, you can email them at titleix@untDallas.edu or file a report [here](#).

Pregnancy, Pregnancy Related Conditions and Parenting Modifications Under Title IX

UNT Dallas is committed to compliance with Title IX, and to supporting the academic success of pregnant and parenting students and students with pregnancy related conditions. If you are a pregnant, have pregnant related conditions or a parenting student (child under one-year needs documented medical care) who wishes to request reasonable related modifications from the University under Title IX, please email the Title IX Coordinator at titleix@untDallas.edu. The Title IX Coordinator will work with your professors and academic unit to provide reasonable modifications needed to be supportive of your education while pregnant or as a parent under Title IX.

Bad Weather Policy:

Campus facilities will close, and operations will be suspended when adverse weather and/or safety hazards exist on the UNTD campus or if travel to the campus is deemed dangerous as the result of ice, sleet or snow. In the event of a campus closure, the Marketing and Communication Department will report closure information to all appropriate major media by 7 a.m. That department will also update the UNTD website, Facebook and Twitter with closing information as soon as it is possible. For more information, please refer to <http://www.untDallas.edu/police/resources/notifications>.

Inclement Weather and Online Classes:

Online classes may or may not be affected by campus closures due to inclement weather. Unless otherwise notified by your instructor via e-mail, online messaging, or online announcement, students should assume that assignments are due as scheduled.

Technology Assistance:

To successfully access the materials in Canvas, UNT Dallas advises that your computer be equipped with the minimum system requirements listed on the first page of the syllabus. If you have trouble accessing or using components of the course, try using Google Chrome browser. If you still experience technical difficulties, first, notify your instructor.

If the problem is still not resolved, call Distance Learning at the phone number listed on the first page of the syllabus. Also, no matter what browser you use, always enable pop-ups. For more information see:

- UNT Dallas Canvas Technical Requirements: <https://community.canvaslms.com/docs/DOC-10721>

Canvas Instructure Support & Unsupported Operating

Systems: <https://community.canvaslms.com/docs/DOC-10720>